Dawson Petersen, PhD

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Employment

Fritz Postdoctoral Research Fellow,
Department of Linguistics and Department of Computer Science,
Georgetown University; Washington, DC
January 2026 –

Education

Doctor of Philosophy, Linguistics,
University of South Carolina; Columbia, SC
August 2020 – December 2025

Master of Arts, Linguistics,
University of South Carolina; Columbia, SC
August 2019 – May 2022

Bachelor of Science, Interdisciplinary Studies – Psychology and Linguistics,
North Greenville University; Tigerville, SC
Summa cum laude
August 2015 - May 2019

Fellowships & Awards

Doctoral Dissertation Research Improvement Grant,
NSF Linguistics Program, 2024
$17,817

Russell J. and Dorothy S. Bilinski Dissertation Fellowship,
University of South Carolina, 2024
$40,000

SPARC Graduate Research Grant,
University of South Carolina, 2024
$4,800

Graduate School Travel Award,
University of South Carolina, 2023, -24
$500, $500

McCausland Innovation Fund Award,
University of South Carolina, 2022
Amit Almor, Dawson Petersen, and Sarah Wilson
$10,000

Linguistics Program Summer Research Award,
University of South Carolina, 2021, -24
$670, $400

Discover USC Graduate Poster Award
University of South Carolina, 2025

Interdisciplinary Student of the Year (BS)
North Greenville University, 2018-2019

Linguistics Student of the Year
North Greenville University, 2017-2018

Research

Publications

Theses & Dissertation

Petersen, D. (2025). Anthropomorphism in language and thought: The effect of agentive linguistic framing on readers' perceptions of AI animacy [PhD Dissertation]. https://scholarcommons.sc.edu/etd/8640/

Petersen, D. (2022). The role of force dynamic schemas in the comprehension of causal language [MA Thesis]. https://scholarcommons.sc.edu/etd/6800/

Petersen, D. (2018). Embodied simulation in response to semantic priming [Unpublished Undergraduate Thesis].

Refereed Publications

Petersen, D. & Almor, A. (In Press). Grammatical agency influences online perceptions of AI animacy. *Cognitive Research: Principles and Implications.*

Petersen, D., Purushothama, A., & Schneider, N. (2026). Sense and sensitivity: "Reasoning" models are more robust, but can diverge from human consensus in a legal interpretation task. *Proceedings of the 30th Conference on Computational Natural Language Learning*. https://openreview.net/forum?id=qlxqZoEuob

Warren, K., Nichols, C., Petersen, D., Shalin, V. L., & Almor, A. (2025). Stylistic language drives perceived moral superiority of LLMs. Reply to: Aharoni et al. (2024). *Scientific Reports, 15*, 39168. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-025-25046-9

Petersen, D. & Almor, A. (2025). Agentive linguistic framing affects responsibility assignments towards AIs and their creators. *Frontiers in Psychology—Cognitive Science, 16*. DOI: http://www.doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2025.1498958

Petersen, D. & Almor, A. (2023). Anthropomorphism, not depiction, explains interaction with social robots. [Peer commentary on the paper "Social robots as depictions of social agents" by H. H. Clark & K. Fischer]. *Behavioral and Brain Sciences, 46*. DOI: http://www.doi.org/10.1017/S0140525X22001698

In Preparation

Petersen, D. & Almor, A. (In Preparation). Rethinking anthropomorphism: A new taxonomy.

Petersen, D. (In Preparation). Are metaphoric ad hoc concepts constructed inferentially?

Presentations

Invited Talks

Petersen, D. (2026, Nov 5). AI anthropomorphism isn't just AI anthropomorphization [Talk delivered for the UA Futures program at SAP User Assistance]. SAP User Assistance.

Petersen, D. (2026, Apr 21). Welcome to the jungle: A brief primer on academic career paths [Workshop for graduate students in computational linguistics]. Georgetown University Linguistics Department.

Petersen, D., Tobia, K., & Schneider, N. (2026, Mar 27). Empirical approaches to legal interpretation. Fritz Family Fellows Conference.

Petersen, D. (2026, Feb 27) The effects of anthropomorphic grammatical framing on readers' perceptions of AI systems [Invited Colloquium Talk]. Georgetown University Linguistics Department.

Petersen, D. (2024, Nov 7). The effects of anthropomorphic linguistic framing on the online processing of texts about AI [Keynote Presentation]. University of North Georgia Linguistics Symposium.

National Conference Presentations

Herman, E., Petersen, D., Schneider, N., & Waldon, B. (2026, Sep 24-25) How does syntactic context modulate restrictive interpretation? Implications for linguistics and law [Poster Presentation]. 6th Experimental Pragmatics in Italy Conference XPRAG.it 2026.

Petersen, D. & Almor, A. (2026, Mar 26-28). Belief verbs increase perceptions of AI animacy during semantic integration, goal verbs do not [Poster Presentation]. The Society for Human Sentence Processing 2026.

Petersen, D., Carney, N. & Almor, A. (2025, Mar 27-29). Grammatical metaphor increases AI-animacy perception in online sentence processing [Poster Presentation]. The Society for Human Sentence Processing 2025.

Petersen, D., Shalin, V. L., Borders, M., Seals, S. M., Nichols, C., & Almor, A. (2024, Nov 21-24). Anthropomorphism mediates the algorithm outrage deficit. [Paper Presentation]. The Psychonomic Society's 65th Annual Meeting 2024.

Petersen, D., Almor, A. & Shalin, V. L. (2024, Jan 10-12). Linguistic framing affects moral responsibility assignments towards AIs and their creators [Lightning Talk]. Agency and Intentions in Language 4. https://ail-workshop.github.io/AIL4-Workshop/docs/AIL4_abstract_booklet.pdf

Petersen, D., Almor, A. & Shalin, V. L. (2023, Nov 16-19). "Dr. A.I." can be convicted of malpractice, but only if the jury is inexperienced with language AI [Poster Presentation]. The Psychonomic Society's 64th Annual Meeting 2023.

Petersen, D. & Almor, A. (2022, Nov 17-20). Force dynamic schemas and the comprehension of causal language [Poster Presentation]. The Psychonomic Society's 63rd Annual Meeting 2022.

Petersen, D. (2022, Nov 4-6). Ad hoc concepts and conceptual metaphors [Paper Presentation]. 5th International Conference of the American Pragmatics Association (AMPRA) 2022.

Dubinsky, S., Gavin, M., Starr, H.; Petersen, D., Rees-White, G., Smith, K.; D'Souza, V., Whalen, L., Ginn, J., Bickham, A. (2022, Jun 27) The Language Conflict Project: Perspectives on 21st century ethnolinguistic conflict [Paper Presentation]. Desmond Tutu Center Conference on Conflict, Communication, and Peace.

Petersen, D. (2022, May 23). Form-interaction mismatch in (im)politeness [Paper Presentation]. X International Symposium on Intercultural, Cognitive and Social Pragmatics 2022.

Petersen, D. (2022, Jan 7). Ad hoc concepts and figurative language: The contribution of conceptual metaphors [Poster Presentation]. Linguistic Society of America 2022.

Regional Conference Presentations

Petersen, D., Herman, E., Conhaim, K., Tobia, K., & Schneider, N. (2026, Oct 5). Understanding AI cases in the U.S. courts [Poster Presentation]. New Directions in Analyzing Text as Data (TADA) 2026.

Petersen, D., Carney, N., & Almor, A. (2025, Apr 25). Grammatical metaphor increases AI-animacy perception in online sentence processing [Poster Presentation]. Discover USC 2025.

Carney, N., Petersen, D., & Almor, A. (2025, Apr 18). Grammatical metaphor increases AI-animacy perception in online sentence processing [Paper Presentation]. University of South Carolina 2025 Linguistics Student Research Symposium.

Nichols, C., Petersen, D., Almor, A., & Shalin, V. L. (2024, Apr 13). AI as an agent: The effects of linguistic framing on descriptions of AI [Paper Presentation]. University of South Carolina 2024 Linguistics Student Research Symposium.

Petersen, D., Almor, A. & Shalin, V. L. (2023, Oct 21). Linguistic framing effects on responsibility assignments towards large language models [Poster Presentation]. The Florida Psycholinguistics Meeting 2023.

Petersen, D. & Almor, A. (2022, Mar 17). The role of force dynamic schemas in the comprehension of causal language [Paper Presentation]. University of South Carolina 2022 Linguistics Student Research Symposium.

Petersen, D. (2021, Mar 20). The metaphoric structuring of the ad hoc concept [Paper Presentation]. University of North Carolina 2021 Linguistics Colloquium.

Lab Experience

NERT @ Georgetown University
Postdoctoral Research Fellow under Nathan Schneider,
Department of Linguistics, Georgetown University
Spring 2026 –

Language and Cognition aLab
Research Assistant for Amit Almor,
Psychology Department, University of South Carolina
Spring 2020 – Fall 2025

Concepts, Language, and the Brain Lab
Research Assistant for Rutvik Desai,
Psychology Department, University of South Carolina
Summer 2024

The Language Conflict Project
Research Assistant for Stanley Dubinsky,
Linguistics Program, University of South Carolina
Spring 2022

Software Proficiencies

R – Proficient
Formal Training through the University of South Carolina

Eyelink Eye-tracking System – Proficient
Formal Training through the University of South Carolina

Python – Intermediate
Self-taught for personal and professional projects

Unity – Intermediate
Self-taught for personal and professional projects

C# – Beginner
Self-taught for personal and professional projects

Teaching

Courses Taught

Linguistics 300: Introduction to Language Sciences, *University of South Carolina*
Upper-level survey of Linguistics, Cross-listed in Psychology and Anthropology

Linguistics 101: Introduction to Language, *University of South Carolina*
Introductory level survey of Linguistics

English 102: Composition and Rhetoric, *University of South Carolina*

English 101: Critical Reading and Composition, *University of South Carolina*

English 101-Q1A: Critical Reading and Composition, *University of South Carolina*
Special section for first-year International Students

Courses Assisted

Linguistics 567: Psychology of Language, *University of South Carolina*
Cross-listed in Psychology

Psychology 420: Survey of Developmental Psychology, *University of South Carolina*

Psychology 3330: Social Psychology, *North Greenville University*

Guest Lectures

Petersen, D. (2026, Nov 9). LLMs for law: Challenges and opportunities [Invited lecture]. Lecture given in AISC – Science of AI. *Georgetown University.*

Petersen, D. (2026, Sep 24). Human subjects experiments in linguistics [Invited lecture]. Lecture given in COSC/LING 5402 – Empirical Methods in Natural Language Processing. *Georgetown University.*

Petersen, D. (2024, Oct 1). Independent sample t-tests [Invited lecture]. Lecture given in PSYC 220 – Psychological Statistics. *University of South Carolina.*

Petersen, D. (2022, Nov 14). Introduction to pragmatics [Invited lecture]. Lecture given in LING 101 – Introduction to Language. *University of South Carolina.*

Petersen, D. (2020, Nov 18). Introduction to psycholinguistics [Invited lecture]. Lecture given in LING 300 - Introduction to Language Sciences. *University of South Carolina.*

Petersen, D. (2020, Feb 3). Language Development [Invited lecture]. Lecture given in PSYC 420 – Survey of Developmental Psychology. *University of South Carolina.*

Academic and Departmental Service

Conference Organizing

Lead Workshop Organizer
"Experimental Pragmatics: Bridging Theory and Praxis"
with invited speakers: Mira Ariel and Anna Papafragou
American Pragmatics Association, November 11, 2023
https://americanpragmaticsassociation.org/xprag-workshop/

Conference Organization Committee Member
Linguistics Program Student Research Symposium,
University of South Carolina,
November 2019

Reviewing Activity

Manuscript Peer Reviewer
Journal of Psycholinguistic Research
August 2026

Proceedings Peer Reviewer
30th Conference on Computational Natural Language Learning (CoNLL)
Selected as an *Outstanding Reviewer for CoNLL 2026*

July 2026

Conference Poster Reviewer
Discover Day, *University of South Carolina*
April 2022

Other Conference Activity

Conference Volunteer & Session Chair
Annual Meeting, *American Pragmatics Association*
November 2022

Conference Volunteer
Annual Meeting, *Linguistic Society of America*,
January 2021, -22

Leadership

Chair, Graduate Student Council
American Pragmatics Association, 2022 – 2025

President, Graduate Students in Linguistics
University of South Carolina, Fall 2021 – Spring 2022

Vice President, Graduate Students in Linguistics
University of South Carolina, Fall 2020 – Spring 2021

Committee Service

Master of Science Admissions Committee
Computational Linguistics Program, Georgetown University, 2026

Graduate Curriculum Committee
Linguistics Program, University of South Carolina, 2024

First-Year English (FYE) Curriculum Subcommittee
English Department, University of South Carolina, 2022